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Redwood City to let Flock Safety contract expire over automatic license plate readers concerns

Police looking for new vendor for automated license plate readers

By Ana Mata, Daily Journal staff

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Redwood City will not automatically renew its contract with Flock Safety for its automatic license plate readers, an investigative technology that has raised concern by residents over privacy, misuse and data sharing.

Gerekli Olmayanları Reddet

Redwood City Police Chief Kristina Bell presented a discussion on the department's ALPR program to the city's Police Advisory Committee Aug. 12, after national scrutiny over Flock cameras.

Flock Safety quickly became the national leader in providing the surveillance technology in recent years, but recently fell under fire for mass data collection and sharing with law enforcement beyond city limits, including federal agencies.

In response, and despite little to no evidence that Redwood City data was shared, Bell and the Redwood City Police Department have decided to let their contract with Flock expire in November and are drafting a new request for proposals from a different company.

A comprehensive audit from April 2023 to May 2026 found that there were various out-of-state and federal departments that had access to Redwood City's data. That access was all credited to mishandling by the vendor, Flock.

Every query of any organization is made available to that organization, so Redwood City can track who searches their data.

In one instance, Flock itself conducted searches that included Redwood City data for demonstration purposes without the city's permission. In another instance, a federal veterans affairs office mistakenly was able to see Redwood City data in its searches due to its home address in California.

"These are the entities Flock granted search permissions to our account, these permissions we never authorized and we were not aware of these permission," Bell said. "This means these agencies were able to submit queries to the network. It does not mean they received Redwood City images in response."

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The main breach in access was due to the fact that Redwood City's data was searchable state-wide, and Flock mislabeled California as being in California. Redwood City data is now restricted to departments within the nine Bay Area counties only.

“These were all due to vendor side classification and permission issues,” Bell said. “The problem was in how Flock categorized other agencies and what permissions Flock granted them, not in what my officers were doing or how we set up our system.”

Flock Safety acknowledged the national issue in March, stating such California agencies “had their camera networks inadvertently accessible to out-of-state law enforcement agencies for a period of time,” according to a previous company statement. The company said it was “impossible to determine a specific cause” for the data breach.

The city’s existing policy on the technology also stated that immigration enforcement, traffic enforcement harassment, intimidation and use based on protected classes such as race, sex and religion are prohibited. It also stated that the technology cannot identify individuals through facial recognition.

Many residents spoke during public comment at the Police Advisory Committee on Wednesday, and while they were pleased that the contract with Flock would be ending, the majority still shared their hope that the department would end the automated license plate reader program altogether.

The preservation of cameras creates fears in the community and puts residents on edge, many said. Breaches in data under Flock’s system also pose a lingering concern that something similar could happen with another provider.

The proposals were due earlier this month, and the department received seven, Bell said. There is no specified deadline by which the department will determine who the city will work with for the program’s future, however, one will likely be selected this fall.

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Following the audit of the existing system, a grand jury report on the surveillance cameras and the national scrutiny over data sharing, Bell said the request for proposals was written with very strict language to reflect the community’s concerns.

Any future contract would be awarded to a company that allows the city to own its data and control all data sharing policies. Vendors must also disclose any relationships with Immigration and Customs Enforcement or other border patrol agencies. The vendor cannot allow for artificial intelligence or secondary uses of the technology and its data. Full ability to audit the program and enforcement must also be allowed.

The cameras were first installed in December 2023, and there are 25 fixed cameras throughout the city.

The automated license plate readers are credited with helping identify a vehicle related to a double shooting, located an elderly at-risk missing adult and stopped an in-progress kidnapping, among other cases, Bell said.

ana@smdailyjournal.com

(65) 344-5200 ext. 106



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